DSEH004 Performance Management and Employee Engagement

Week 8 | Lecture 1 | Unit III

Generations at Work: Evidence over Stereotype

What the research supports, what it does not, and how to design for age without stereotyping

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Commit before theory

A survey shows employees under 28 want to change jobs far more than those over 50. What best explains this?

A Gen Z is less loyal than earlier generations

B Younger people at any time in history move more

C Today's job market encourages everyone to move

D We cannot tell from a single survey

Mannheim: a generation is a shared experience

A generation is a group that shares formative experiences at a similar age, not simply people born in the same years

Location

Born at a similar time and place

Actuality

Exposed to the same formative events

Unit

Responds to them in a shared way

The age, period and cohort problem

1 Age

Differences due to life stage: career building, caregiving, nearing retirement

2 Period

Differences due to the current moment, affecting everyone, such as a hot job market

3 Cohort

Differences due to the era in which a group grew up

In one cross-sectional survey, age and cohort are perfectly confounded, so a generation effect cannot be separated from a life-stage effect

What the evidence says

Study	Finding	Implication
Costanza et al. (2012)	Generational differences in satisfaction, commitment and intent to turn over are small to moderate, and likely reflect other factors	Do not build PM around generation labels
Twenge et al. (2010)	Time-lag data: valuing of leisure rose, and social and intrinsic values fell, across cohorts	Some cohort shifts exist, but are modest
Kooij et al. (2011)	Age relates positively to intrinsic motives and negatively to growth and extrinsic motives	Age, not generation, may drive motive change
Posthuma and Campion (2009)	Common stereotypes of older workers are largely unsupported	Stereotypes create risks of bias

Socioemotional selectivity: time changes goals

Open time horizon

- Goals focus on knowledge and new contacts
- Willing to trade comfort for growth
- More common earlier in life

vs

Limited time horizon

- Goals focus on emotional meaning
- Prefer deep, trusted relationships
- More common later in life, or in any limited period

Carstensen et al. (1999): perceived time, not age itself, shapes motivation, which offers a better design lever than birth year

Designing for age without stereotyping

Start from needs

Diagnose motives and constraints by life stage and situation

Offer choice

Flexible menus rather than generation-specific programs

Test for bias

Check ratings and promotions for age effects

Measure within

Compare the same people over time, not cohorts in one survey

The loyalty problem at a textile exporter

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Tiruppur garment exporter finds that 70 percent of exits in the last year were employees under 28. The owner plans a Gen Z engagement program with social media badges and gaming nights. Older supervisors complain that young workers do not respect hierarchy.

Work it through

1. What alternative explanations exist for the exit pattern?
2. What data would separate age from cohort effects?
3. Which stereotype risks appear in the supervisors' comments?
4. Redesign the program around needs rather than labels

Common confusions to avoid

A tempting reading	A better reading
Gen Z is less loyal	Younger workers at any time move more; cohort effects are small
Older workers resist change	This stereotype is largely unsupported by evidence
Design programs by generation	Design by need, life stage and choice

Exam-style question

Critically evaluate the use of generational categories in designing engagement strategy, with reference to Costanza et al. (2012). (20 marks)

What a strong answer does

- Explains Mannheim's concept and the age, period and cohort problem
- Summarizes Costanza et al. and Twenge et al. accurately and with nuance
- Uses Kooij et al. and Carstensen et al. to offer better explanations
- Proposes a non-stereotyping design and a test for age bias

Sources

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